



“I’m not going to say if someone has X in the KPIs, X-50 is what I’m going to do in affirmative action for an LGBTQ+ candidate. It’s about what is the best we can get out of you if we create the required enabled environment”

ZAINAB PATEL
CHIEF INCLUSION
OFFICER, PERNOD
RICARD INDIA



“I faced a lot of backlash—graffiti in the washrooms, sexual harassment, etc. When I tried to address it [her sexuality] without coming out, it was very difficult. I had to leave the workplace”

SONAL GIANI
SENIOR TECHNICAL ADVISOR
(DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION),
INTERNATIONAL PLANNED
PARENTHOOD FEDERATION

we go by trust and don’t require any certifications,” he says.

With many LGBTQ+ candidates also experiencing mental health conditions due to violence and stigma, expecting them to perform at the same level as other employees may not be fair either, say some. The key is to set goals in accordance with what can be achieved without underplaying too much, says Zainab Patel, Pernod Ricard India’s Chief Inclusion Officer who identifies as a transgender woman. “I’m not going to say if someone has X in the KPIs, X-50 is what I’m going to do in affirmative action

for an LGBTQ+ candidate. It’s about what is the best we can get out of you if we create the required enabled environment. That’s how my current and former employers did it,” she says, adding that mainstreaming opportunities are more helpful. The alcoholic beverage maker, along with TISS, offers 15 transgender candidates a one-year paid Transformation Fellowship where they are trained in skills such as creating business plans and office etiquette, followed by internships at leading corporates.

A lot of good cultural change happens from the top, say experts.

While allyship and sensitive leadership are powerful, not many from the LGBTQ+ population get hired in senior positions where they can effect policy change. Axis Bank’s Iyer agrees: “We (the LGBTQ+ population) have people in the middle- and lower-management levels who identify as queer, but not in the top management. That’s the case with queer people worldwide.”

It is not that companies are not looking to hire for senior positions, adds Pride Circle’s Sinha. “People also must be comfortable to engage. The more senior people have been in the closet for a longer period and feel that they have a lot at stake career-wise, if they come out. Fewer of them are accessing avenues that support LGBTQ+ people with jobs.” Organisations say they can neither force people to disclose their identities nor can they push people after entry levels to get promoted because they are from a diverse background. PhonePe’s Sandhu says there continues to be a fear of disclosing identities in this macro environment. “At least, we are able to do focussed recruitment. But my counterparts in the UK, the Netherlands and Canada cannot even do such drives because one is not allowed to encroach into privacy and say ‘I want an LGBTQ+ leader,’” says Tata Steel’s Sanyal. The best possible thing to do is to ensure more and more LGBTQ+ candidates enter the fray to increase the probability of promotions, say the corporates. For that to happen, experts say both employers and employees must come on board to turn baby steps into a 24x7 way of being, 365 days a year. Just populating June, the Pride month, with rainbow arches and flags will not do. **BT**

@SaysVidya, @mittermaniac